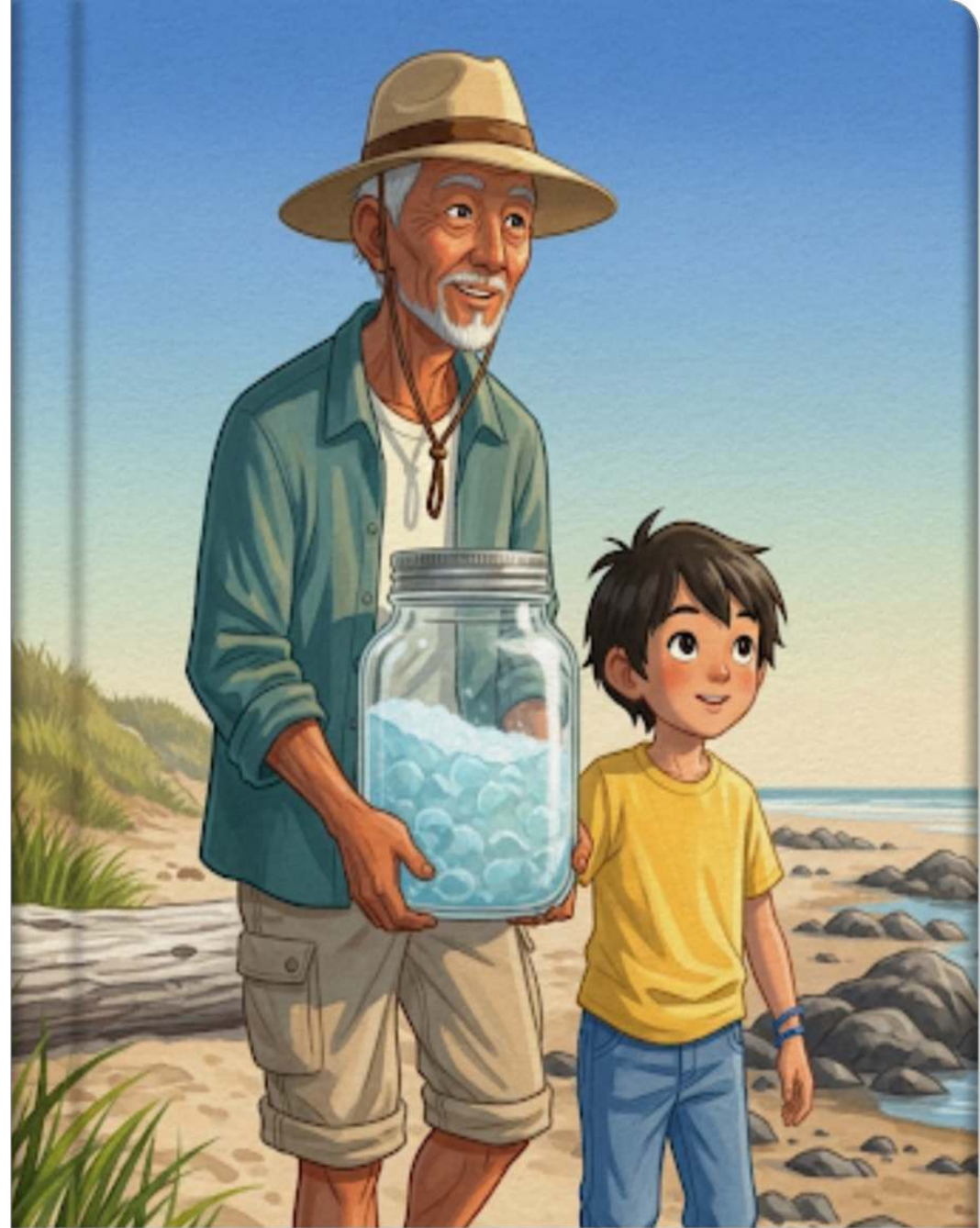




The Jar of Ocean Jewels - Anxiety Edition

By Michael Mendez



Kai and Soren walked along the shoreline where the waves whispered to the sand. For Kai, the beach didn't feel peaceful today. Instead, he carried a "Stormy Feeling" in his chest—a buzzing, fluttering worry that made his hands feel shaky. Soren noticed Kai looking at the horizon with wide, restless eyes. "A worry is like a rogue wave, Kai," Soren said gently. "It looks big and scary, but it always breaks and turns into foam."



The "Stormy Feeling" made Kai feel like he was moving too fast and too slow all at once. His thoughts were like a swarm of dragonflies, darting here and there, making it hard to focus on the pretty shells at his feet. He sat down on a piece of silver driftwood, hugging his knees tightly. He wished he could just click a button and make the "Big Worry" go away so he could feel steady again.



Soren sat down on the sand nearby, leaving enough room for Kai to feel the breeze. "When the storm inside gets too loud, Kai, we breathe like the sea," Soren said. He placed one hand on his stomach and the other on his heart. "The air comes in like a slow, rising tide... and goes out like the receding water." Kai watched Soren's steady shoulders. Slowly, Kai tried it too, focusing only on the rhythm of his own breath.



Soren reached into his bag and pulled out a glass jar. Inside were "Ocean Jewels"—bits of sea glass in every color, all smooth and soft. "These started as sharp, broken pieces of bottles," Soren explained. "The ocean didn't throw them away. It tumbled them and smoothed them until they became treasures." He held a frosted blue piece up to the light. "Our worries can be tumbled, too, until they don't feel so sharp."



A small, bright-eyed bird named Teal landed on a nearby rock. Teal was fluttering his wings frantically and chirping in a high, panicked voice. He seemed afraid of the crashing waves and kept hopping from one foot to the other, unable to stay still. Kai saw the "Stormy Feeling" in the bird's jittery movements and felt a sudden wave of empathy for the little creature.



"It's okay, Teal," Kai whispered, his voice calm and steady. "I feel the buzz, too." Kai stayed very still, becoming a quiet anchor for the bird. Teal stopped fluttering and hopped onto Kai's finger. As Kai felt the tiny weight of the bird, he realized his own "Stormy Feeling" was beginning to settle. By helping Teal find his calm, Kai was finding his own, too.



Kai found a jagged piece of clear glass that had recently washed ashore. It was sharp and reminded him of the "What If" thoughts that often kept him awake at night. "This is what my worry feels like," Kai said. He didn't drop it. He just looked at it. He knew that with time and deep breaths, even the sharpest "What If" could be tumbled into a smooth jewel.



"Let's find the world again, Kai," Soren said, standing up. "Tell me three things you can hear right now." Kai closed his eyes and listened past the storm in his head. "I hear the seagulls calling," he said. "The water splashing against the rocks. And the wind whistling in the grass." Soren nodded. "Those sounds are real. They are happening right now. And right now, you are safe."



That night, Kai sat on the porch with Teal resting on his shoulder. The moon made a silver path across the ocean. The waves were still moving, always changing, just like his feelings. He wasn't afraid of the "Big Worry" anymore. He had his jar of jewels, his wise friend Soren, and the secret of the sea: that every storm eventually turns into a calm, sparkling tide.